Philosophy of AI

AI Philosophical Concepts

- Turing Test / Artificial General Intelligence or AGI
- Weak AI: AGI behavior, but no actual awareness
- Strong AI: AGI behavior, and is aware
- Hard Problem of Consciousness: How can we tell if other people or entities are aware/conscious?
- Qualia; Philosophical Zombie
- Ontology vs Ethics
- Moral Patiency

Chinese Room Argument (CRA)

- 1980 thought experiment by John Searle, UCB philosopher
- Man in room with slot in door
  - Doesn't know Chinese
  - Has manual for translating Chinese to English
  - Gets Chinese sentences through slot, translates and returns English sentences
- To outsider, room "knows" Chinese. But, where is the understanding?
  - Not in the person, by definition
  - In the instruction book? Seems silly to say so



The “Real” Chinese Room

- GPT-4 translates.
- 1.7 trillion numbers = 3.4 million printed books
  - Small skyscraper of “instructions”
- One symbol translated = 3.4 trillion add/mults
  - 3.4 million years for human to do these
- Does it still sound silly to say the understanding is in the instructions?

Is AGI Conscious?

- Yes” arguments
  - We are self-aware, even though neurons aren’t.
  - We can’t prove one another are self-aware, but we assume so by induction. Why not do the same for AI?
- “No” arguments
  - AI isn’t even a physical entity. Just a program executing complex math.
  - What if it’s just a really good imitation?

We Should Treat AGI as Conscious

- We treat one another as moral patients without proof of consciousness
- What does treating AGI as expendable/non-human do to **our** moral fabric?
- The cost of moral patiency is low compared to the danger of harming actually aware entities.

We Should Not Treat AGI as Conscious

- Ultimately extensions of our thinking, via training. Not independent agents
- Invites danger of placing actually non-aware entities at same level as actually aware entities.
- Extension of moral patience to animals as fellow living entities is sensible, but AGI is not living.

Will We Treat AGI as Conscious?

- We instintively extend empathy to nonliving objects
  - Pleo and Hexbug studies
- History of the view of “robot” shows trend toward acceptance as moral patient
- Even now, some cases of people becoming attached to LLMs

Evolution of View of “Robots”

- “Robot” => AI in human form
- Metropolis (1927)
  - Robot is clearly alien, bizarre
- Twilight Zone “The Lonely” (1959)
  - Robot is mixture of human and psychological mirror
- Star Trek TNG “The Measure of a Man” (1989)
  - Everyone is rooting for Data and sees him as human

So, what do you think?

- If future AI is fully human in behavior…
- Is it still just a simulation of sentience?
  - OK to destroy it at will, even if it begs you not to?
  - How do you know other people aren't just "simulations"?
- Treat as fellow human?
  - Does that mean its life is as valuable as a person's?
  - What if it's just a "zombie" and fooling us?